

Astrological Birth Signs in Suicide: Hypothesis or speculation?

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ABSTRACT

Astrology is no longer regarded as a science by many, because its claims are almost impossible to test empirically in controlled laboratory conditions and it can not meet the scientific need to be reproducible.

However, the majority of those who read their 'star signs' can identify aspects of their personality in what they read and it is possible that this may influence their attitudes and actions. The literature has neglected astrological signs as a possible predictor of suicide ideation.

To see whether astrological birth signs are associated with suicide and the method used, data was collected from the Public Health Department in North Cheshire representing all the Cheshire Coroner's verdicts of suicide, and open verdicts, in all deceased aged 60 and above between 1989 and 2000.

The observed occurrence of deaths due to natural causes, and suicide, in relation to birth signs did not differ significantly from what would be expected from chance.

However, the distribution of suicide by hanging appeared significantly higher in those with a birth sign of Virgo and lowest in Sagittarius and Scorpio.

The distribution of violent and non-violent suicides in relation to star signs showed higher occurrences of violent death in persons born in the summer months.

INTRODUCTION

Current fascination with horoscopes is likely to stem from man's primary instinct; fear of the unknown. In times of need or uncertainty, be it applying for a new job or sitting exams, superstition, with its roots in ancient history, penetrates our thoughts.

Today astrology does not claim to predict the future, but simply to give some impression of

people's characters and hence how predictable certain events might be in their lives. Large numbers of the general public will not only be aware of their star sign but will proceed to read 'the nonsense' that features in so many of our newspapers.

Most people will agree with many of the statements made about them as long as they are sufficiently general. The majority of those who read their 'star signs' can identify aspects of their personality in what they read, and it is possible that this may influence their attitudes and actions. However the literature has neglected astrological signs as possible predictors of suicide ideation. Stack and Lester (1988), surveying 7,058 responders, concluded that astrological birth signs were not predictive of suicide attitudes, but they reported that more people born under Pisces expressed suicide attitudes compared with others.

METHOD

To see whether an astrological birth sign is associated with suicide and the method used, data was collected from 502 records of the Public Health Department in North Cheshire, representing all the Cheshire Coroner's verdicts of suicide, and open verdicts, between 1989 and 2000. The date of birth was converted into the corresponding star sign (Table I) for each suicide victim over a period of 12 years, and also for those who died of natural causes during a two-year period in North Cheshire (6,951) for comparison.

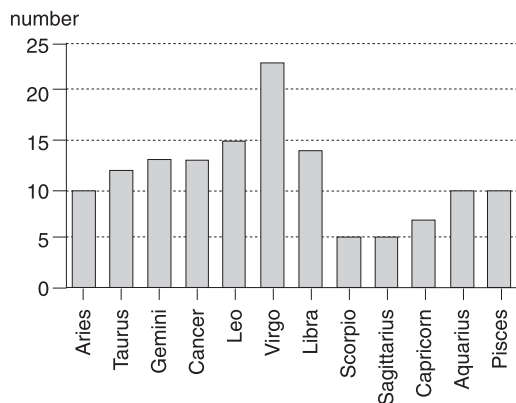


Figure 1. Astrological birth signs in suicide by hanging.

RESULTS

The main methods of suicide in the sample were: overdose 194 (39%), hanging 136 (27%), drowning 35 (7%), car exhaust 59 (12%), shooting 10 (2%), immolation 4 (1%), wounding 13 (2.5%), asphyxia 14 (3%), jumping from a height 17 (4%), electrocution 5 (1%) and hit by a train 15 (3%). The results in relation to birth signs are summarised in Table I.

The observed occurrence of deaths due to natural causes and suicide in relation to birth signs did not differ significantly from what would be expected by chance.

However the distribution of suicide by hanging appeared significantly higher in those with a birth sign of Virgo, and lowest in Sagittarius and Scorpio (Figure 1), than would be expected by chance (Goodness of Fit χ^2 23 df11 $P < .01$ $n=136$). Differences between the observed and expected frequencies of methods used in suicide, other than hanging, in relation to astrological star signs failed to reach statistical significance.

Suicide methods were then grouped as:

- (1) Non-violent death which included: ICD-9 (WHO 1977 Codes) E950 = Self poisoning by solid or liquid; E951 = Gas in domestic use and E952 = Other gases and vapour.
- (2) Predominantly violent death which included all methods other than self-poisoning (E953 = Hanging, strangulation and suffocation; E954 = Drowning; E955 = Firearms and explosives; E956 = Cutting or piercing

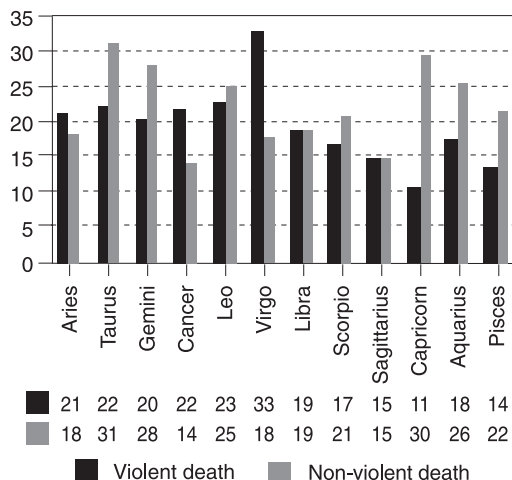


Figure 2. Astrological birth signs in suicide (North Cheshire 1989-2000).

instruments; E957 = Jumping from a high place; E958 = Other methods).

Figure 2 shows the distribution of violent and non-violent suicide in relation to star signs, with higher frequencies of violent death occurring in those born in the summer months.

DISCUSSION

Astrology is not regarded as a science by many because its claims are almost impossible to test empirically in controlled laboratory conditions, and it cannot meet the scientific need to be reproducible. However it is not unusual for persons to be able to identify some aspect of their personality in the characteristics listed for their birth sign. The extent to which these astrological predictions of personality are true, and the reason for this, can be highly variable and influenced by many contributory factors. It may be assumed that some people who internalize attributes that astrologists assign to their birth signs might believe that they are predestined to a life characterised by loss, and may indeed feel more depressed and hopeless. If such were the case, it could be anticipated that such persons would be more approving of suicide (Stack and Lester, 1988). On the other hand, there may be some scientific explanation. The association between the month of birth and mental illness has been repeatedly

Table 1. Proportion of deaths due to natural causes and suicide in North Cheshire by astrological birth signs.

Cause of death	Birth Sign											
	Aries 21/3-20/4	Taurus 21/4-21/5	Gemini 22/5-21/6	Cancer 22/6-23/7	Leo 24/7-23/8	Virgo 24/8-23/9	Libra 24/9-23/10	Scorpio 24/10-22/11	Sagittarius 23/11-21/12	Capricorn 22/12-20/1	Aquarius 21/1-19/2	Pisces 20/2-20/3
Natural causes X ² 8 df 11 P=0.6 n=6951	8.5%	8%	8.3%	8.6%	8.4%	8.4%	8.3%	7.9%	7.8%	8.2%	7.6%	8.1%
Suicide X ² 12 f 11 P=0.3 n=502	7.8%	10.6%	9.6%	7.2%	9.6%	10.2%	7.6%	7.6%	6%	8.2%	8.8%	7.2%
Overdose X ² 14 df 11 P=0.2 n=194	7.7%	11.3%	10.8%	5.7%	8.8%	6.7%	6.2%	7.2%	6.2%	12.9%	8.2%	9.3%
Hanging X ² 23 df 11 P=<.01 n=136	7.4%	8.8%	9.6%	8.8%	11%	16.9%	10.3%	3.7%	3.7%	5.1%	7.4%	7.4%
Drowning X ² 9 df 11 P=0.6 n=35	17.1%	2.9%	8.6%	8.6%	8.6%	8.6%	2.9%	14.3%	11.4%	2.9%	8.6%	5.7%
Car exhaust X ² 10 df 11 P=0.5 n=59	8.5%	11.9%	11.9%	3.4%	11.9%	5.1%	10.2%	10.2%	3.4%	3.4%	13.6%	6.8%
Other methods X ² 10 df 11 P=0.5 n=78	6.4%	14.1%	5.1%	10.3%	7.7%	11.5%	6.4%	10.3%	9%	7.7%	9%	2.6%
	5	11	4	8	6	9	5	8	7	6	7	2

examined in modern psychiatry. Castrogiovanni et al. (1998) reviewed 81 studies in the northern hemisphere, confirming the predominance of winter births seen among schizophrenics and a higher spring/summer birth rate among alcoholics and those with mood disorders.

Low CSF levels of 5-HIAA have been found in persons displaying violent suicidal behaviour such as hanging, stabbing, using firearms or jumping from a height and impulsivity (Asberg, 1997; Mann and Malone, 1997). Chotai and Asberg (1999) reported some significant season-of-birth variations in 5-HIAA and HVA levels in the CSF. Persons born during the winter-spring months of February to April had significantly lower values of 5-HIAA. The Swedish findings of season-of-birth variations in serotonin metabolite 5-hydroindoleacetic acid (5-HIAA) may be applicable but only to suicide incidents in North Cheshire involving those born in winter months and mostly of non-violent deaths. Violent suicide in this study seems higher in those born in summer months (Figure 2).

Whether the findings in this review, interpreted as a positive association between suicide by hanging and the Zodiac sign of

Virgo, or an inverse relationship with Sagittarius and Scorpio, is information of no scientific validity, or a case of celestial interventions, remains an 'open verdict'!

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